

women that I was the best choice as I was one of them," she says.

This strategy worked in her favour again in 2005, when she was contesting to retain her seat. Veena was framed in a murder case immediately after the announcement of the results. Against all objections, she turned herself in to the Superintendent of Police, seeking an impartial probe and offering to stay arrested till then. The officer supervised the probe and the charges were dropped. A day after, she took an oath for her second term.

Veena, however, admits that she became a leader by accident. "I was unlettered, but after I became a widow in 1989, I started taking interest in social affairs. We were a group of women, willing to change the world but without an idea about how to do it," she says.

Destiny gave her an opportunity wrapped in a tragedy in 1990. A child was killed in a road accident in Nawada, prompting Veena and her friends to block the road. The administration immediately paid compensation to the victim's mother. An all-woman group staged a second blockade when the electricity transformer

KIRISHWA MURAR-KIRISHWA

stopped functioning. It was replaced in a jiffy. Veena had tasted blood. The next story was on a personal front—a criminal, who was a tenant in late her husband's home, refused to pay the rent. When she asked him for it, he threatened to shoot her. Repeated petitions to the police were in vain, so she and her group had him evicted.

Recently, she launched a campaign to make widows self-reliant in the villages of Loharpura Panchayat. So far, it's been a success. For instance, Sunita, a young widow, was appointed as a community-based accredited social health activist, for which she is paid Rs 3,500 per month, by the National Rural Health Mission.

On any typical day, Veena, dressed in a white sari, can be spotted travelling in a public vehicle, though many other panchayat chiefs in Bihar have bought SUVs. She walks briskly through the crowded streets and dusty passages, dodging sleeping dogs, striking conversation with housewives rolling rotis and with groups of men chatting at leisure. All the women come forward to hold her hand. Many have questions and almost always Veena has a solution. One can be sure this is not part of some political campaign as the next elections are still years away. This is part of her routine—effortlessly striking a bond that keeps her afloat in the male-dominated state. She has the confidence to confront the strongest man in her panchayat if he is wrong. She has a purpose—an abiding commitment that transcends any individual agenda.

There hasn't been a single case filed against anyone since Veena was elected for her second term. In fact, she has persuaded everyone in her Panchayat not to take their differences to a police station. Instead, they approach Veena who sorts out their problems by talking to them. "I know the repercussions of a police case. So I dissuade villagers from filing a case. We thrash it out," she says. For instance, in May, when two groups of villagers had a tussle and stopped the construction of a school funded by Veena, she did not call the police. Instead, when her reasoning failed to deter the two camps, she went on a Munnabhai-like fast. She had to be admitted in a hospital after two days, but the warring factions relented and apologised. The construction has resumed.

For everyone in Nawada, Veena's satyagraha ways are an inspiration. Her message to all is empowering and universal: I did it, and so can you. ■

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